

DESCARTES 1

MEDITATIONS ON FIRST PHILOSOPHY

In which the existence of God and the distinction between the human soul and the body are demonstrated

FIRST MEDITATION

What Can Be Called into Doubt

Some years ago, I was struck by the large number of falsehoods that I had accepted as true in my childhood, and how doubtful the subsequent structure I had built upon them was. I realized that if I wanted to establish anything firm and lasting in the sciences, I had to completely demolish everything once in my life and begin again right from the foundations. But the task seemed very challenging, and I began waiting until I reached an age mature enough to ensure that no future period of my life would be more suitable for undertaking such inquiries. This caused me to postpone the project for so long that I would now be at fault if I wasted the remaining time by deliberating further rather than putting it into action. Therefore, today, having freed my mind from all anxieties and having secured a period of leisure for myself, I am here completely alone, and I will finally devote myself wholeheartedly and unreservedly to the general overthrow of my opinions. But to accomplish this, it will not be necessary for me to show that all my opinions are false, which is something I might perhaps never achieve.

Now my reason leads me to think that I should hold back my assent from opinions that are not completely certain and indubitable just as carefully as I would from those that are manifestly false. Thus, in order to reject all my opinions, it will be sufficient to find at least some reason for doubt in each of them. To do this, I will not need to examine them all one by one, which would be an endless task. When the foundations of a building are undermined, whatever is built upon them collapses of its own accord; for this reason, I will direct myself straight toward the basic principles upon which all my former beliefs rested.

Whatever I have accepted up to now as most true, I have acquired either through my senses or from the senses. But I have occasionally found that the senses deceive, and it is prudent never to trust completely those who have deceived us even once.

Although the senses sometimes mislead us regarding objects that are very small or in the distance, there are many other beliefs about objects where doubt is almost impossible, even if they are derived from the senses—for example, that I am sitting here by the fire, wearing a winter dressing gown, holding this piece of paper in my hand, and so on. Again, how could it be denied that these hands or this entire body belong to me? Unless, of course, I were to compare myself to madmen whose brains are so damaged by the persistent vapors of melancholia that they stubbornly insist they are kings when they are destitute, or that they are dressed in purple when they are naked, or that their heads are made of clay, or pumpkins, or glass. But these people are mad, and I would appear no less mad if I were to take any of them as a model for myself.

A brilliant piece of reasoning! As if I were not a man who sleeps at night and regularly experiences in sleep all the same things, or sometimes even more improbable ones, than those madmen do while awake. How often, asleep at night, am I convinced of such familiar things—that I am here in my dressing gown, sitting by the fire—when in fact I am lying

naked in bed! Yet at this moment my eyes are certainly wide open as I look at this paper; I shake my head and it is not asleep; when I reach out and feel my hand, I do so knowingly and with awareness. All this would not appear so distinct to someone asleep. Indeed! As if I did not remember other occasions when I was deceived by precisely similar thoughts while sleeping! When I consider this more carefully, I see plainly that there are never any certain indications by which being awake can be distinguished from being asleep. As a result, I begin to feel dazed, and this very feeling reinforces the notion that I might be dreaming.

Suppose then that I am dreaming, and that these particular details—that my eyes are open, that I am moving my head, and that I am extending my hands—are not true. Perhaps I do not even have such hands or such a body at all. Nevertheless, it must surely be admitted that the visions which come in sleep are like paintings, which must have been fashioned in the likeness of things that are real, and thus at least these general kinds of things—eyes, head, hands, and the body as a whole—are not imaginary, but real and existing things. For even when painters strive to create sirens and satyrs with the most extraordinary bodies, they cannot assign them entirely new natures in every respect; they merely mix together the limbs of different animals. Or perhaps, if they manage to invent something completely novel, fictitious, and untrue, the like of which has never been seen before, at least the colors used in the composition must be real. By similar reasoning, even if these general kinds of things—eyes, head, hands, and the like—might be imaginary, it must at least be granted that certain other things, simpler and more universal, are real. These are the true colors from which all images of things in our thought are formed, whether true or false.

This class appears to include corporeal nature in general and its extension; the shape of extended things; the quantity or size and number of these things; the place where they may exist, the time during which they may endure, and the like.

Hence, a reasonable conclusion to draw from this is that physics, astronomy, medicine, and all other disciplines dependent on the study of composite things are doubtful; whereas arithmetic, geometry, and other subjects of this sort, which treat only the simplest and most general things, regardless of whether they exist in nature or not, contain something certain and indubitable. For whether I am awake or asleep, two and three added together make five, and a square has no more than four sides. It seems impossible that such transparent truths could incur any suspicion of being false.

And yet there is an opinion long entrenched in my mind that an omnipotent God exists who created me as the kind of creature I am. How do I know that He has not brought it about that there is no earth, no sky, no extended thing, no shape, no size, and no place, while at the same time making it appear to me that all these things exist just as they do now? Furthermore, just as I sometimes judge that others are mistaken in matters they think they know most perfectly, how do I know that He has not brought it about that I too am deceived whenever I add two and three, or count the sides of a square, or judge of something even simpler, if such can be imagined? But perhaps God would not allow me to be deceived in this way, since He is said to be supremely good. Yet if it were contrary to His goodness to have created me such that I am constantly deceived, it would seem equally contrary to His goodness to allow me to be deceived even occasionally; however, this last assertion cannot be maintained.

Perhaps there may be some who would rather deny the existence of so powerful a God than believe that everything else is uncertain. Let us not argue with them, and let us grant that

everything said about God is a fiction. Then, according to their assumption, I reached my present state by fate, chance, a continuous chain of events, or some other means; but since deception and error seem to be imperfections, the less power they ascribe to the author of my origin, the more likely it is that I am so imperfect as to be continuously deceived. I have no answer to these arguments, but finally I am forced to admit that there is not one of my former beliefs about which it is impossible to doubt.

And this is not a rash or ill-considered conclusion, but one based on powerful and well-thought-out reasons. Therefore, if I wish to discover anything certain in the future, I must withhold my assent from these former beliefs just as carefully as I would from obvious falsehoods.

Yet merely noticing this is not enough; I must make an effort to remember it. My habitual opinions keep returning and, despite my wishes, take hold of my belief, which has become bound to them as if by long-standing custom and the law of familiarity. I will never lose the habit of deferring to and trusting these opinions so long as I suppose them to be what they really are—namely, highly probable opinions which, though in a sense doubtful as has just been shown, are far more reasonable to believe than to deny. For this reason, I think it will be a good plan to turn my will completely in the opposite direction and deceive myself by pretending for a while that these former ideas are entirely false and imaginary. I will continue to do this until the weight of preconceived opinions is balanced, and the distorting influence of habit no longer prevents my judgment from perceiving things correctly. Meanwhile, I know that no danger or error will come from this course, and that I cannot go too far in my distrustful attitude, since the task at hand involves not action, but merely the acquisition of knowledge.

I will suppose, therefore, that not God, who is supremely good and the source of truth, but rather a supremely powerful and cunning demon has devoted all his energies to deceiving me. I will consider that the sky, the air, the earth, colors, shapes, sounds, and all external things are nothing other than the illusions of dreams that he has devised to entrap my judgment. I will consider myself as having no hands, no eyes, no flesh, no blood, and no senses, but as falsely believing that I possess all these things. I will stubbornly and resolutely persist in this meditation; and even if it is not in my power to know any truth, I will at least do what is in my power—that is, I will resolutely avoid giving assent to any falsehood, so that this deceiver, no matter how powerful and cunning he may be, will be unable to impose anything on me.

But this is a laborious undertaking, and a kind of laziness brings me back to ordinary life. I am like a prisoner who enjoys an imaginary freedom in his dreams; when he begins to suspect that he is asleep, he fears being awakened and conspires with the pleasant illusion for as long as possible. In the same way, I willingly slip back into my former opinions and dread being shaken out of them, lest my peaceful sleep be followed by arduous labor, and I have to toil not in the light, but amid the impenetrable darkness of the difficulties that have just been raised.

SECOND MEDITATION

The Nature of the Human Mind, and How It Is Better Known than the Body

The doubts into which I was plunged as a result of yesterday's meditation are so serious that I can neither sweep them from my mind nor see any way of resolving them. I feel as if I have unexpectedly fallen into a deep whirlpool that tumbles me around in such a way that I can neither stand on the bottom nor swim to the surface. Nevertheless, I will make an effort and

once again follow the same path that I began yesterday. I will set aside everything that admits of the slightest doubt, just as if I had found it to be completely false; and I will continue in this manner until I recognize something certain, or at least until I recognize for certain that nothing is certain. Archimedes used to demand just one firm and immovable point in order to shift the entire earth from its place; so too, I may hope for great things if I succeed in finding just one thing, however small, that is certain and unshakeable.

I will suppose, then, that everything I see is false. I will believe that my memory tells me lies and that none of the things it reports ever happened. I have no senses. Body, shape, extension, motion, and place are chimeras. What, then, remains? Perhaps just the fact that nothing is certain.

Yet how do I know that there is not something else, aside from those things I have just listed, about which there is not the slightest room for doubt? Is there not some God, or whatever name I call it, who puts into me these thoughts I now possess? But why should I think that, when perhaps I myself could be the author of these thoughts? In that case, am I not at least something? But I have just said that I have no senses and no body.

Here lies the crux: what follows from this? Am I so bound to a body and to senses that I cannot exist without them? But I have convinced myself that there is absolutely nothing in the world: no sky, no earth, no minds, and no bodies. Does it now follow that I too do not exist?

No: if I convinced myself of something, then I certainly existed. But there is a deceiver of supreme power and cunning who deliberately and constantly deceives me. In that case, if he deceives me, then undoubtedly I too exist; and let him deceive me as much as he can, he will never bring it about that I am nothing so long as I think that I am something. Therefore, after having thought everything through thoroughly, I must conclude that the proposition "I am, I exist" is necessarily true whenever it is put forward by me or conceived in my mind.

Yet I do not yet have a sufficient understanding of what this "I" is, which now necessarily exists. Hence, I must take care not to carelessly mistake something else for this "I," and thus fall into error in the very item of knowledge that I maintain to be the most certain and evident of all. For this reason, before proceeding further with this chain of thought, I will reflect deeply on what I originally believed myself to be. Then I will subtract everything that could be weakened even slightly by the arguments just advanced, so that ultimately what remains is purely and solely that which is certain and unshakeable.

What, then, did I formerly think I was? A man. But what is a man? Shall I say "a rational animal"? No; for then I should have to inquire what an animal is, and what rationality is, and thus one question would lead me into more difficult ones, and I do not now have the leisure to spend on such subtleties. Instead, I propose to focus on what came spontaneously and naturally into my mind whenever I thought about what I was. The first thought that occurred to me was that I had a face, hands, arms, and the whole mechanical structure of limbs, such as can be seen in a corpse, which I designated by the name "body." The next thought was that I nourished myself, moved about, engaged in sensory perception, and thought; and these actions I attributed to the soul. But as to what this soul was, either I did not think about it at all, or I imagined it to be something very tenuous, like a wind, fire, or ether, infused throughout my more solid parts. As for the body, however, I had no doubts, but thought I distinctly knew its nature. If I had attempted to describe the mental conception I had of it, I would have expressed it as follows: by a body I understand whatever has a determinable

shape and a definable location, and can occupy space in such a way as to exclude any other body; it can be perceived by touch, sight, hearing, taste, or smell, and can be moved in various ways, not by itself, but by whatever else comes into contact with it. For, according to my judgment, the power of self-movement, just like the power of sensing or thinking, was completely foreign to the nature of a body.

Indeed, the fact that some bodies were found to possess such capacities was a source of astonishment to me.

What, then, shall I say that I am, now that I suppose that there is a supremely powerful and—if I may say so—malicious deceiver who has been deliberately striving to deceive me in every possible way? Can I now claim to possess even the least of all the attributes that I just said belong to the nature of a body? I examine them, think about them, review them over and over, but nothing comes to mind; going through the list again is tiresome and pointless. What about the attributes I assigned to the soul? Nutrition or movement? Since I have no body, these are merely fictions. Sense perception? This certainly cannot occur without a body, and besides, I have often noticed that in sleep I seemed to perceive through the senses many things that I later realized I had not perceived in that way. Thinking? At last I have discovered it: thought; this alone cannot be separated from me. I am, I exist—that is certain. But for how long? For as long as I think. For it could be that if I were to cease all thinking, I would completely cease to exist. At present, I admit nothing that is not necessarily true. I am, therefore, strictly only a thinking thing; that is, a mind, an intellect, an understanding, or reason—words whose meanings were previously unknown to me. Yet I am a real thing and truly exist. But what kind of thing? As I have just said: a thinking thing.

What else am I? I will use my imagination. I am not that structure of limbs called the human body. Nor am I some fine vapor infused among these limbs; not a wind, fire, air, breath, or whatever I can depict in my imagination, for I have supposed these to be nothing. Let that assumption stand; nevertheless, I am still something. Yet is it not possible that these very things which I suppose to be nothing because they are unknown to me are not in fact identical with the "I" of which I am aware? I do not know, and I will not argue the point for now, because I can pass judgment only on things that are known to me. I know that I exist; the question is, what is this "I" that I know? If the "I" is understood precisely as taken so far, then its knowledge cannot depend on things whose existence is still unknown to me, and therefore cannot depend on anything that I invent in my imagination.

Second Meditation

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...depends on things whose existence is still unknown to me; therefore, it cannot depend on anything that I invent in my imagination. And this very word "invent" shows me my mistake. If I were to use my imagination to prove that I was something, this would indeed be a fictitious invention; for imagining is simply contemplating the shape or image of a corporeal thing. But now I know with certainty both that I exist, and that at the same time all these images, and in general everything pertaining to the nature of the body, could be nothing but

dreams (and illusions). Once this point is grasped, to say "I will use my imagination to know more distinctly what I am" would appear just as foolish as saying "I am now awake and see a little truth; however, because my vision is not yet clear enough, I will deliberately go to sleep so that my dreams might provide a more genuine and distinct representation". Thus, I understand that nothing which the imagination allows me to grasp has anything to do with this knowledge I have of myself, and that for this reason, the mind must be most carefully withdrawn from such things so that it may perceive its own nature as distinctly as possible.

What then am I? A thinking thing. What is that? A thing that doubts, understands, affirms, denies, wills, refuses, and also imagines and has sensory perceptions. This is a considerable list, if indeed everything on it belongs to me. But is it so?

Is it not this very same "I" who now doubts almost everything, yet understands some things, claims that one thing is true, denies everything else, desires to know more, is unwilling to be deceived, imagines many things even involuntarily, and is aware of many things that seemingly come from the senses? Even if I am perpetually dreaming, or even if the one who created me uses all his power to deceive me, is not every one of these as true as the fact that I exist? Which of these activities is distinct from my thinking? Which of them can be said to be separate from myself? The fact that it is I who doubts, understands, and wills is so evident that I see no way of making it any clearer. But it is also true that the "I" who imagines is the exact same "I". For even if, as I have supposed, none of the objects of the imagination are real, the power of imagining really does exist and is a part of my thinking. Finally, it is the same "I" who has sensory perceptions, or who is aware of corporeal things as if through the senses. For instance, right now I see light, hear a sound, feel heat. But I am dreaming, so all of this is false. Yet I certainly seem to see, hear, and be warmed. This cannot be false; what is called "having sensory perception" is strictly just this, and in this restricted sense, it is nothing other than thinking.

'From conceiving in this manner' (French version)

From all this, I begin to understand what I am somewhat better. But it still seems—and I cannot help thinking—that corporeal things, whose images are formed in my thought and which the senses investigate, are known far more distinctly than this confusing "I" which cannot be pictured in the imagination. Yet it is indeed astonishing that I should have a clearer grasp of things that I realize are doubtful, unknown, and foreign to me, than of those that are real and known to myself. But I see how it is: my mind enjoys wandering off and will not yet submit to being restrained within the bounds of truth. Very well then; let us give it completely free rein just this once, so that later on, when the time comes to tighten the reins, it may submit to being curbed more easily.

Let us consider the things that people think they understand most distinctly—namely, the bodies we touch and see. I am not speaking of bodies in general, for general perceptions tend to be rather more confused; I am referring to a particular body. Let us take, for instance, this piece of wax. It has just been taken from the honeycomb; it has not yet completely lost the taste of honey; it still retains some of the scent of the flowers from which it was gathered; its color, shape, and size are plain to see; it is hard, cold, and easily handled; and if you tap it with your finger, it makes a sound. In short, it has everything that seems necessary to enable a body to be recognized as distinctly as possible. But even as I speak, I put the wax near the fire and look: the remaining taste disappears, the scent vanishes, the color changes, the shape is lost, the size increases; it becomes liquid and hot; you can hardly touch it, and when you tap

it, it no longer makes a sound. But does the same wax remain? It must be admitted that it does; no one denies it, no one thinks otherwise.

What was it, then, that I understood so distinctly in the wax? Clearly, none of the features that I reached through the senses; for taste, smell, sight, touch, or hearing have now altered, yet the wax remains. Perhaps the answer lies in the thought that has just occurred to me: namely, that the wax was not the sweetness of the honey, the fragrance of the flowers, the whiteness, the shape, or the sound; rather, it was a body that presented itself to me in various forms just a moment ago, but now exhibits different ones. But what exactly am I imagining now? Let us concentrate, remove everything that does not belong to the wax, and see what remains: nothing other than something extended, flexible, and mutable. But what is meant here by "flexible" and "mutable"? Is it what I picture in my imagination: that this piece of wax can change from a round shape to a square shape, or from a square shape to a triangular shape? Not at all; for I understand that the wax is capable of countless changes of this sort, yet I cannot run through this immeasurable number of variations in my imagination; from which it follows that it is not the faculty of imagination that enables me to grasp the wax as flexible and mutable.

And what is meant by "extended"? Is not the extension of the wax also unknown? For the wax extends further when it melts, extends even more when boiled, and increases still further as the heat increases. I would not form a correct judgment about the nature of the wax if I did not believe that it is capable of undergoing far more variations in extension than I could ever grasp in my imagination. I must therefore grant that the nature of this piece of wax is in no way revealed by my imagination, but is perceived by the mind alone. (I am speaking of this particular piece of wax; the matter becomes even clearer when wax in general is considered.) But what is this wax which is perceived by the mind alone? Surely it is the same wax that I see, touch, picture in my imagination, and in short, have thought of from the very beginning. Yet the essential point is that my perception of it is not an act of sight, touch, or imagination, and despite earlier impressions, it never was; it is purely an inspection of the mind, which can be imperfect and confused as it was before, or clear and distinct as it is now, depending on how carefully I concentrate on what the wax contains.

But when I reach this conclusion, I am astonished at how prone my mind is to error. For even though I consider these matters within myself, quietly and without speaking, actual words still trip me up and ordinary modes of speech almost mislead me. If the wax is before us, we say that we see the wax itself, not that we judge it to be there from its color or shape; and this might lead me to conclude, without further ado, that knowledge of the wax comes from what the eye sees, rather than from the inspection of the mind alone. But then, if I happen to look out the window and see men crossing the square, I ordinarily say that I see the men, just as I say that I see the wax. Yet what do I see more than hats and coats, which could conceal automatons? I judge that they are men. And thus, something that I thought I saw with my eyes is actually grasped solely by the faculty of judgment in my mind.

However, anyone who wishes to attain knowledge above the ordinary level should be ashamed to derive grounds for doubt from ordinary forms of speech. Let us proceed, then, and consider in which case my perception of the nature of the wax was more perfect and distinct. Was it when I first looked at it and believed that I knew it through my external senses, or at least through what they call "common sense"—that is, the imaginative faculty? Or is my knowledge more perfect now, after a more careful investigation of the nature of the wax and how it is known? Any doubt on this matter would clearly be foolish; for what distinctness was

there in my earlier perception? Was there anything in it that an animal could not possess? But when I distinguish the wax from its external forms—as if I had stripped it of its garments and viewed it naked—even if my judgment might still contain errors, my perception at least now requires a human mind.

What, then, shall I say of this mind, or of myself? (For up to now, remember, I admit nothing in myself other than a mind.) What, I ask, is this "I" that seems to perceive the wax so distinctly? Surely the awareness of my own self is not only far more real and certain than my awareness of the wax, but also far more distinct and clear. For if I judge that the wax exists from the fact that I see it, the very same fact entails far more evidently that I too exist. It is possible that what I see is not really wax; it is even possible that I do not have eyes with which to see anything. But when I see, or think I see (I make no distinction between the two here), it is impossible that I, who am now thinking, am not something. Likewise, if I judge that the wax exists from the fact that I touch it, the same result follows—namely, that I exist. If I judge that it exists because I imagine it, or for any other reason, the same conclusion follows. And what I have observed in the case of the wax can be applied to everything else that exists outside of me. Furthermore, if my perception of the wax appeared more distinct after being determined not merely by sight or touch, but by many other considerations, I must admit that I now know myself even more distinctly. This is because every consideration that contributes to my perception of the wax, or of any other body, cannot fail to establish the nature of my own mind far more effectively. But besides this, there is so much in the mind itself that can serve to make my knowledge of it more distinct that the contributions made by considering corporeal things hardly seem worth examining.

Without any effort, I see that I have finally returned to where I wanted to be. I now know that even bodies are perceived not by the senses or by the imaginative faculty, but by the intellect alone, and that this perception derives not from their being touched or seen, but from their being understood; and for this reason, I clearly know that there is nothing I can perceive more easily or more distinctly than my own mind. But since the habit of clinging to former opinions cannot be set aside so quickly, I wish to pause here and reflect a while on this newly acquired knowledge, so that I may imprint it more deeply upon my memory.

1. Introduction — Aim and Method Descartes decides to radically question all the beliefs he has held since childhood in order to reach certain and unshakeable knowledge. He wants to build a firm foundation for the sciences, and to do so he plans to dismantle all his previous ideas down to their roots and rebuild them. His method for this is methodic doubt: he will accept nothing as true unless it is absolutely certain. 2. Methodic Doubt and Its Purpose Methodic doubt is the key instrument Descartes uses to achieve his aim. Instead of questioning every belief one by one, he targets the basic principles on which those beliefs rest. If these foundations prove unreliable, then everything built on them also becomes doubtful. This allows a more efficient and radical reformation of knowledge. 3. The Deception of the Senses The first target of doubt is the senses. Descartes notes that the senses sometimes deceive us—through illusions, distance, or misleading appearances. If the senses have deceived us even once, then they cannot be fully trusted as a source of certain truth. A fallible source cannot yield absolute certainty. 4. No Clear Distinction Between Wakefulness and Dreaming Descartes intensifies his doubt by introducing the dream argument. Many of the experiences we have while awake closely resemble those in dreams, and in dreams we often believe we are experiencing reality. Since there is no definitive sign that tells us whether we

are awake or dreaming, sensory information becomes even more unreliable. 5. Doubt Toward Mathematical Truths Descartes goes further: even mathematics might be doubted. If there exists a very powerful being capable of deceiving him, then even the clearest truths—like $2+3=5$ —could be manipulated in his mind. This possibility pushes doubt to its most radical form. 6. The Evil Demon Hypothesis To formalize this extreme doubt, Descartes proposes the “evil demon” hypothesis: imagine an all-powerful, malicious deceiver who dedicates all his power to misleading us. Under this assumption, the existence of the external world, the body, and even logical truths become questionable. Nothing from his old beliefs survives this level of doubt. 7. The Existence of a Subject Who Doubts But does this radical doubt eliminate everything? Descartes realizes that even if he doubts everything, the very act of doubting requires a subject who doubts. In order to be deceived, he must exist at least in some form. This insight prepares the ground for the famous cogito. 8. Cogito: “I think, therefore I am” What survives radical doubt is Descartes’ famous conclusion: the act of thinking proves his existence. Even if he is deceived, even doubting confirms that there is a “self” that thinks. Thus the statement “I think” is undeniably true, and from it the conclusion “I exist” follows with certainty. The cogito becomes the first absolutely certain truth. 9. Questioning the Nature of the Self After establishing that he exists, Descartes asks what this “I” actually is. Previously, he might have assumed that he was a combination of body and mind, but these assumptions relied on unexamined beliefs. Since the existence of the body is doubtful, the certain “I” must be something that does not depend on the body. 10. Res Cogitans — The Thinking Thing Descartes concludes that what he certainly is, is a thinking thing (*res cogitans*). Thinking includes doubting, understanding, affirming, denying, willing, imagining, and sensing. All these mental activities are certain because they are directly experienced, even if the bodily world is uncertain. 11. Distinguishing Imagination from Thought He distinguishes imagination from pure thought. Imagination involves mental images tied more closely to the body and therefore remains doubtful. For true knowledge, the mind must rely on pure thought, especially on what is clear and distinct, rather than on sensory images or imagination. 12. The Wax Example: Perception and Understanding In the famous wax example, Descartes shows that external objects are known not by the senses but by the intellect. When a piece of wax melts, all its sensory qualities—smell, taste, shape, texture—change, yet we recognize it as the same wax. This demonstrates that the mind understands the essence of the wax through intellect, not through fluctuating sensory data. 13. The Priority of the Mind as a Source of Knowledge The wax example also shows that perception is actually a process involving judgment and intellectual grasp, not mere sensory input. The essence of the object—its extension, flexibility, spatial properties—is understood by the intellect. Thus, the mind is a more reliable source of knowledge than the body or senses. 14. Conclusion — The Certainty of the Mind By the end of the Second Meditation, Descartes establishes the mind as more certain than the body. The cogito proves the existence of a thinking self, and the wax example demonstrates the mind’s role in understanding the nature of external things. This becomes the foundation upon which Descartes will later build arguments for the existence of God and the external world. 15. Summary and Preparation for Later Meditations To summarize: the First Meditation creates radical doubt (senses, dreams, the evil demon), and the Second Meditation uncovers the first indubitable truth—“I think, therefore I am”—and clarifies the nature of the thinking self. Together, these meditations prepare the groundwork for reconstructing knowledge on firm foundations.